

MUSIC

Together We Play

Hindustani classical musicians **Purbayan Chatterjee** and **Rakesh Chaurasia** have collaborated on an album that makes audible their affection for each other

In early March, sitar maestro Purbayan Chatterjee and flautist Rakesh Chaurasia headed to a small studio in their hometown Mumbai to work on a new record. At the time, Chatterjee was riding high on the success of his 2021 album *Unbounded (Abaad)*, a progressive jazz/rock/Hindustani classical extravaganza that packed in stellar performances by a star cast of global virtuosos, including Ustad Zakir Hussain, Béla Fleck, Michael League and Shankar Mahadevan.

But now he and Chaurasia—accompanied by Satyajit Talwalkar and Ojas Adhiya on tabla—were on a slightly different mission. With the easy chemistry that only comes from decades of friendship and collaboration, the duo recorded seven tracks of free-flowing *raga*-based *jugalbandi*, nailing most of their takes in one go. The result of that freewheeling recording session is the new album, *Saath Saath*, which was released independently in September.

"*Unbounded* was an exploration where I had free rein to venture into uncharted territory and add many different elements to each song," says Chatterjee in an e-mail from the US, where the duo is currently on tour. "I wanted to see what I could do with that freedom in my own mind if I got back to the exploration of *ragas*. All my fellow artists on this record are contemporary masters and are very modern in their approach. So, *Saath Saath* is a homecoming album... a home with a view of the world."

"SAATH SAATH is a homecoming album... a home with a view of the world," says Chatterjee

The music on *Saath Saath* is based on seven *ragas* that are associated with different times of the day, progressing from the cinematic serenity of opener Lalit to the playfully romantic build-and-release of the mid-day *raga* Madhuvanti, and then the more free-wheeling folksy improv of evening raga Pahadi. The incredible synergy among between the four artists—all of whom are also family friends—is an electric, intimate conversation between sitar, bansuri and percussion where every witty exchange and subtle melodic interplay is as thrillingly engaging as a David Attenborough documentary.

"Music cannot just be played or sung alone, there must be a sense of 'togetherness'," adds Chaurasia, referencing the album's title which translates to 'together'. "[Mine and Purbayan's] friendship has been truly special as it goes back more than 30 years. That has helped make this musical journey memorable."

With the album already out, Chatterjee and Chaurasia are busy presenting it to the world with a month-long US tour and a minor detour to the Barbican in London, where they're set to perform a set at the Darbar Festival. Both are, of course, veterans of the international tour circuit, but there is something a little special about this one. "It's a great feeling to tour to promote the record," says Chatterjee. "We have done Atlanta and as I sit and write this interview, we are on a plane to Indiana. Post the pandemic, the feeling of being on the road is kind of surreal. Bringing our music to audiences all over the world is not just what we do, it is who we are." ■

Bhanuj Kappal



JUGALBANDI
Flautist Rakesh Chaurasia and sitar maestro Purbayan Chatterjee have been friends for over 30 years